the United States of America, including an article by [columnist Walter] Lippmann [in the *Washington Post* on October 25], where it was said that the Russians could raise the question of liquidating the USA bases in Turkey," recalled Mikoyan a few weeks later. "They were speaking about the possibility of such a demand inside American circles. This question was discussed in the USA. Turkish bases do not have great importance for us. They will be eliminated in case of war. True, they have certain political significance, but we don't pay them special importance, though we will seek their liquidation."[17]

Khrushchev began to dictate his letter to Kennedy there at the meeting of the Presidium. Seven members of that body, including Mikoyan, his nemesis Malinovsky, the cautious Gromyko, and the often-silent Brezhnev took part in the discussion and eventually approved the final text. As no reply had yet been received from Kennedy to Khrushchev's letter of the previous day, the new letter was styled as a response to Kennedy's reaction to U Thant's proposal to lift the blockade in exchange for Khrushchev's promise not to send weapons to Cuba. Khrushchev had agreed to U Thant's proposal, while Kennedy had not, but one could not tell that from Khrushchev's new letter to the president.

Unusually for the recent correspondence between the two leaders, Khrushchev's new missive began on a positive note. "Dear Mr. President," wrote Khrushchev, "I have studied with great satisfaction your reply to Mr. Thant concerning measures that should be taken to avoid contact between our vessels and thereby avoid irreparable and fatal consequences. This reasonable step on your part strengthens my belief that you are showing concern for the preservation of peace, which I note with satisfaction." Despite the argument he had made at the Presidium meeting, Khrushchev did not explicitly admit the presence of ballistic missiles and nuclear warheads on the island, calling them only "means that you regard as offensive." But he made it clear that they were under sole Soviet control, and his comparison of them with the American missiles in Turkey left no doubt what they were.

"You are disturbed over Cuba," continued Khrushchev, coming to his main point. "You say that this disturbs you because it is 90 miles by sea from the coast of the United States of America. But Turkey adjoins us; our